objective annual reporting by the European Commission. The monitoring approach will be the same in every Member State.

There can be no compromise when it comes to defending our core values. Threats to the rule of law challenge the legal, political and economic basis of how our Union works.

The Commission's monitoring will be done in close dialogue with national authorities on the basis of law, notably the recent case law set down by our independent Court of Justice. I will also ensure a greater role for the European Parliament in this rule-of-law mechanism.

The new way forward brings transparency, allows early detection and offers targeted support to resolve any issues at an early stage.

Our objective is to find a solution that protects the rule of law, with cooperation and mutual support, but without ruling out an effective, proportionate and dissuasive response as a last resort.

I intend to focus on tighter enforcement, using recent judgements of the Court of Justice showing the impact of rule-of-law breaches on EU law as a basis. I stand by the proposal to **make the rule of law an integral part of the next Multiannual Financial Framework.**

This is about strengthening trust and confidence between us, which is as good for our internal market as it is for our internal unity.

The Commission will always be an independent guardian of the Treaties. Lady Justice is blind – she will defend the rule of law wherever and by whomever it is attacked.

Strong borders and a fresh start on migration

I will propose a New Pact on Migration and Asylum, including the relaunch of the Dublin reform of asylum rules.

I am aware of how difficult and divisive discussions on this issue are. We need to allay the legitimate concerns of many and look at how we can overcome our differences. We need to look at it in a comprehensive way.

We need strong external borders. A centrepiece in this ambition is **a reinforced European Border and Coast Guard Agency**. Agreeing the next Multiannual Financial Framework on time will allow us to reach a standing corps of 10,000 **Frontex** border guards earlier than the current target of 2027. I want to see these guards with the ability to act at the EU's external borders in place by 2024.

We have to modernise our asylum system. A **Common European Asylum System** must be exactly that – common. We can only have stable external borders if we give enough help to Member States facing the most pressure because of their place on the map. We all need to help each other and contribute.

These two steps forward will allow us to **return to a fully functioning Schengen Area of free movement**, a key driver of our prosperity, security and freedoms. But we need to improve the way it works and pave the way for a potential further enlargement of the area.

We need a new way of burden sharing. We need a fresh start.

Our responsibility starts in the **home countries** of those who come to Europe. People do not choose lightly to leave their